Steve smiles fondly as Bucky twirls the brunette on the dancefloor, his movements fluid and confident. It feels good, seeing him in his element, even when the gnawing ache makes Steve's chest tight and his throat dry.

Since his own date has abandoned him after just half a song – hey, at least half a dance, that's more than usual – he picks up his jacket and heads for the door. Outside, he leans against the brick wall, hearing the chatter and laughter mixed with lively music pour through the door as someone opens it. For the approximately hundredth time, he wishes his lungs would allow him to smoke; just so he'd have something to do while he waits for Bucky to notice his absence, charm his dancing partner into forgiving his early departure and maybe kiss her in a darkened corner to make up for it. It would be much easier for Steve to stand out here, casually light up and blow smoke rings into the cold autumn night, than simply wait, not quite relaxed enough to be bored with a hint of guilt tugging at his coattails. He'd never do this to Bucky if he was on a date that actually mattered to him, he never has, but today has been enough of a struggle as is. All he wants right now is to slouch on one of their battered kitchen chairs and hear Bucky's infectious laughter.

"Ouff, I might have been too dashing tonight. She barely let me leave! For a second, I was scared she might drop down to one knee and propose to me right there on the dancefloor," Bucky exclaims as the door closes behind him and he turns towards Steve who rolls his eyes.

"Of course, Buck. You prefer people on both knees, that's for sure," Steve responds and takes glee in Bucky's ensuing performance of indignation barely covering a snicker.

"Steve! Your accusation hurts me deeply, have you no respect for my virtue?"

"Just as much as you have for it."

That earns Steve a playful elbow in his ribs as they walk down the steps and head towards their apartment.

The night is cool, but not too cold to force Steve into an annoying number of layers to keep warm. He is dreading the coming months with their harsh winds, unrelenting rains followed by snow that somehow always finds its way into Steve's cheap boots when it melts. Last winter, his pneumonia got so bad that he had, at one point, wondered aloud at whether it was important to have his last rites read to him by an actual priest. Bucky had turned pale, paler than Steve had ever seen him and the dark circles under his eyes had stood out even more prominently. Still, Bucky had refused to even entertain the notion and told Steve that he wasn't allowed to die, not now, not ever, because he would leave the world so much worse off without him.

But this winter will be better, Steve promises himself without anything to back it up as he strolls down the street with Bucky, comfortably silent and happy to breathe in the clear air. Well, semi-clear, this is still New York, of course.

Stumbling inside, Steve kicks off his shoes carelessly, throws his jacket on the floor and falls onto one of the creaking chairs they had found abandoned on a sidewalk one afternoon, not too long after they had moved in together. Bucky swiftly glares at Steve as he puts his shoes next to the door, neatly placed so no one would trip over them and picks up the abandoned jacket to hang it on the coat rack. In response, Steve just shrugs with an innocent smile that turns a little wicked as Bucky tilts his head, obviously unimpressed with his antics. He disappears into the bathroom to wash the sticky pomade from his hair and Steve gets up to open the bottle of wine he snuck from a lavish picknick some rich assholes were having in the park this summer.

“What are we celebrating? You dancing with Annie or you fucking up so badly she left you standing there after like, ninety seconds?” Bucky teases as he comes back, towel over his shoulders and his shirt open. He grins as he rubs his hair, leaving it damp and impossibly messy.

“Pfft, you better watch it or I’ll tell all the girls how goofy you look without your hair slicked back,” Steve returns the grin and hands his friend the bottle.

“Oh, please do, I’m positive they’d want to make sure you’re not lying and invite me to shower with them immediately.”

Both chuckle as they pass the bottle back and forth, lazily taking sips and putting their feet up on the windowsill. The view isn’t much, just a small alley with bins at the end and a brick wall on the opposite side, but there is a small sliver of sky visible just above the roof of the other building. After a few minutes, Bucky turns his head and Steve feels his gaze lingering.

“Seriously though, what happened there on the dancefloor? I know you always say you don’t care. But tonight, you cared enough to ask her to dance, and it still didn’t work out.”

Steve shakes his head.

“I don’t know. I really don’t. Maybe I don’t want to.” A deep sigh empties his lungs, leaving behind a defeated feeling. “I probably should, though.”

In an effort to lighten the mood after a few minutes of silence, he muses: “On the other hand, we can’t all be natural charmers like you, Barnes. That would destroy society faster than any war ever could.”

Bucky barks out a laugh.

“My charm is the result of hard work and intense training; I’ll have you know.”

“Sure. And looking like that has absolutely nothing to do with why all the ladies swoon when you tell a mediocre joke.”

“Mediocre? This is toeing the line with slander, Rogers! You better be careful.”

“Oh yeah? What lawyer are you gonna hire to sue me for that slander? Do you think there’s one that accepts stolen cans of soup or torn up shoelaces as payment?”

“Tsk, tsk, tsk,” Bucky scolds playfully, smiling slyly before his expression fades to something more earnest as he looks out the window again. “You know I think you look plenty fine. I can’t quite figure out why not more dames agree with me but I’m looking forward to when you finally meet one that sees you for the great guy you are.”

Steve just nods slowly, knowing full well that pointing out all of his features that are generally deemed unattractive would not convince Bucky. He has tried before, avoiding the warm fuzziness spreading all over his body at his friend’s words and instead explaining the myriad of reasons why it made sense no one wanted to date him, to no avail. It is genuinely nice that Bucky doesn’t see him like that, even if it doesn’t mean what the aching heat in Steve’s gut wishes it did.

“And we have to prepare you for that day, Stevie, so you don’t chase her away by doing something awful on the dancefloor. If you can’t tell me what went wrong today, you’ll just have to show me and I’ll give you some hint,” Bucky says with unwavering determination in his voice as he stands up, taking a last swig of wine and offering his hand to Steve.

Staggered by the request, Steve just blinks as his own hands start to sweat and a sense of dread intertwined with anticipation rises within him. Still too stunned to speak, never mind object, he gets up and pushes his chair aside, creating space for them to dance. Then, he processes what they are about to do and crosses his arms, leaning against the window.

“Bucky, that’s- no, we’re not doing that. Why- How did you even come up with that idea?” Steve manages to ask.

“Well, I’m good with the ladies, like you always say, so I know what to do and I can give you some pointers.”

“I’m not dancing with you, letting me lead like I’m one of your dames.”

“No, of course not, you’re leading. I doubt the woman of your dreams will let you overhaul the entire concept of dancing on your first date.”

With a little shake, Steve resists the urge to blurt out his suspicion that there might be no woman of his dreams, that his dreams are condemned to stay behind closed doors and not allowed in dancehalls, as illegal as they are sinful – although he has developed his doubts about the latter.

“There’s no music.”

Bucky just laughs, extending his hand once again and this time, Steve takes it, still hesitant, and loosely wraps his arm around Bucky’s waist. Even though he barely had a glass of wine, his head feels light and dizzy as he stands so close to his friend, his best

friend who smells like soap, aftershave and a bit of sweat. He can barely lift his head to look at him, forcing a deliberately unbothered facial expression and raising his eyebrows.

“Now what?”

“You’re leading, you have to initiate. Just imagine a steady rhythm and start to dance.”

Steve takes a deep breath and attempts a simple foxtrot, anxiously surveying his own feet. He does alright, to his own surprise, and Bucky follows easily, moves in concert with his somewhat steady movements.

“See? It’s not that difficult. You’re getting the steps right, so the problem clearly isn’t there.”

A small huff escapes Steve at the suggestion that his dancing alone could be the reason Annie had developed the sudden urge to leave the dance floor without him.

“But you’re staring at the ground, Steve. You have to look at the woman, otherwise she might get the idea you’re more interested in her shoes than her,” Bucky adds and Steve silently braces himself to look him in his eyes. This is bad, very bad. Sometimes he can barely stand to look at those stormy, blue eyes across the room without losing himself in them, without reaching out to pull Bucky close, inevitably receiving the most damning rejection he can imagine.

Bucky huffs in exasperation and uses his left hand that previously laid on Steves arm to lift his chin until their eyes lock. Accepting the treacherous ache deepening inside him, Steve blinks once to signal his understanding to whatever Bucky said.

“Was that so hard now?” he teases fondly, the accompanying smile soft and earnest.

“I guess not,” Steve grumbles out of habit, determined to not falter under the gaze of his friend. His best friend, his best friend since forever, his best friend who loves women, who might be appalled by Steve’s feelings or, maybe even worse, might simply not return them and leave Steave behind in this shabby apartment.

With this mixture of profound dread and deep yearning and his eyes fixed on Bucky’s face, he barely notices the minutes pass, accompanied only by the sounds of the city outside and the shuffle of their feet. Somehow, the two have closed the gap between them in the course of their silent dance and Steve can feel the rise and fall of Bucky’s chest against his own. His head is now tilted more than it was before to keep looking into his eyes. Bucky seems almost shy, his typically self-assured expression having changed to something softer, making his face appear so much more touchable, more kissable. His faintly red lips are parted, and his warm breath falls barely noticeably on Steve’s face.

With horror, Steve notices that he has stared at Bucky’s lips for an indeterminate length of time and swiftly glances at him but finds, to his surprise, that his friend’s gaze is also lingering on the lower half of his face, possibly on Steve’s own lips. Only for a second though, as they come promptly to a halt with Steve’s confusion hitting him like a ton of

bricks. They stare at each other, this time without the pretense of dancing. Neither one of them says anything as Steve risks another glance at Bucky's lips, looking back up and barely breathing from the tension. Bucky seems to search for something in Steve's face and after a moment, his gaze wanders to Steve's lips as he slowly lowers his head. With his heart pounding in his chest as if he had just sprinted around the block, Steve tilts upwards and meets Bucky's lips. They are warm and soft, and Steve feels Bucky's shuddering breath pouring into his mouth as he opens it, kissing him slowly and carefully as if Bucky might push him back at any moment.

Instead, Bucky's hand slips to Steve's neck, caressing the sensitive skin under his ear as their tongues touch delicately. Steve steps even closer and lets his fingers gently roam over Bucky's cheek, still smooth from the shave late in the day. For a few moments, Steve's head is deliciously empty, no thoughts interfering with the sensation as their kiss turns from tentative and reverent to deep and demanding. Steve briefly sinks his teeth into Bucky's pillowy lower lip, cautiously biting without hurting him, and elicits a delectable groan from him. Steve opens his eyes and grins, finding Bucky's gaze and freezing for a moment as the reality of what they are doing crashes over him. He is kissing his best friend, his best friend he shares an apartment with, his best friend who does not suffer from the same lack of enthusiasm for dating women. But before he can start to panic over it, Bucky crowds him against the wall and kisses him again, hot and without restraint, as hands slide over Steve's narrow sides, his ribs, his waist, before settling on his hips. Steve barely suppresses a moan as he touches Bucky's strong shoulders under his open shirt. God, how much time he had spent failing at not imagining what this would feel like – and he still wasn't nearly ready for it to be this good.

With their lips and tongues touching in a heated, ever-changing dance, Steve pushes Bucky's shirt off of him and he briefly refrains from touching Steve so he can undress him. In return, Bucky quickly works at Steve's buttons, helps him out of his shirt and starts to kiss his neck, playfully biting his left earlobe as his hand wanders down, down, down, to Steve's inner thigh and the edge of his crotch. This time, Steve moans shamelessly, the touch too intense and arousing to do anything to stop himself. Obviously pleased with himself, Bucky smiles at him, a hunger in his eyes that Steve has not dared to dream of. Steve returns the smile as his fingers find Bucky's nipples, carefully caressing them, and reveling in Bucky's desperate noises as he closes his eyes, lost in the pleasure for just a second. Against his hip, Steve can feel Bucky hard and hot and he fully intends to slip his hand down there when Bucky starts to kiss his way down his throat, collarbone and chest, rucking up his undershirt to press his lips to his sternum, his stomach until he lingers over Steve's trousers, forehead resting against the sensitive skin just above the waistband. Steve's hands tug at Bucky's shoulders, suddenly helpless at the unexpected loss of hot skin against Steve's chest.

"Jesus, Stevie, will you ever let someone just take care of you?" Bucky says, his panting betraying the mocking tone of his voice. Steve huffs out a laugh and Bucky looks at him,

grinning at first and then raising his eyebrows with an earnestness that takes Steve's breath in a new way.

"Do you want this?" Bucky asks, quietly, with his hands hovering above Steve's fly – and Steve nods without hesitation.

While Bucky helps Steve out of his pants and boxers, Steve cards his hands through his dark hair, soft and still a little damp. He cannot believe this is happening as Bucky kisses his inner thighs, hands resting on his exposed hipbones. Refusing to think about what this might mean for the future, he finally feels Bucky's mouth, hot and wet, around his cock. A groan rips out of him as he looks at the ceiling, then closes his eyes, because all he wants is to focus on the heat searing through every part of his body. He can feel Bucky's tongue soft, so soft on him, before Bucky pulls off, licks his right hand before taking him into his mouth again, now with the hand stroking his shaft. Steve's fingers bury themselves in Bucky hair as he starts to move his head, drawing quick pants from Steve as the pleasure builds in him and he has to lean against the wall, afraid to lose his footing. The hand on his hip now pins him gently down where he stands, with Bucky obviously noticing his slight swaying. Steve glances down and sees that Bucky has closed his eyes, fully focused on what he is doing with a content expression on his face.

"Bucky, I'm gonna – oh Jesus, Buck," Steve stammers in an effort to warn him and Bucky must have heard him as he picks up the pace, making no effort to pull off. This tips Steve over the edge, a massive wave of pleasure hitting him as he moans and shudders, coming while Bucky continues to move his head and licks him through going soft. Catching his breath, Steve disentangles his fingers from Bucky's hair to grip the doorframe next to him while Bucky leans his head against his thigh before getting up.

They look at each other, and Steve sees something flicker over Bucky's face, something he can't quite read, just before Bucky takes his face into his hands and kisses him again, softly, deeply, carefully. Steve fully intends to touch Bucky, to make him feel like he just did, but as soon his hand wanders to Bucky's hip, he stops kissing Steve and pulls him into a hug, pressing his face into Steve's neck and inhaling deeply. For a few seconds, they stay like this, Steves slightly confused but comforted and satisfied in a tight hug, Bucky breathing into the soft skin in the crook of Steve's neck.

Then, Bucky abruptly breaks away, looking at the floor and faking an unbothered, cheerful voice: "I stake my claim on the bathroom!" before leaving Steve there, reeling from the sudden shift.

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It's been almost a week, five agonizing days since the dance – and they still haven't as much as acknowledged what happened. Bucky knows that this is likely more his fault than Steve's with him rushing away like the coward he is, but he still blames Steve just as much for not bringing it up. Being mad about that is so much easier than figuring out what the hell is going on with him whenever he thinks of it.

Determined to bring it up, Bucky starts to button his shirt and walks towards the kitchen to down the cup of coffee he trusts Steve has made for him like every morning. Fortunately, things haven't changed that much and Steve stands there, drinking from his favorite cup and nodding in the direction of Bucky's coffee.

It has become harder, much harder, to see Steve without noticing his soft hair, his defiant lips, his long lashes and the sharp look in his eyes. Bucky does his best not to think of all the rest of him – his neck, his hands, his hipbones – as he swoops into the room and plans to casually hint at last week without actively saying anything. He needs to know everything is okay between them; the tension of the last few days has become unbearable despite its subtlety.

"Good morning to you, too, Rogers," he says, cringing at his overly enthusiastic tone that doesn't quite fit into their habit of teasing. Steve just shoots him an annoyed glance before going back to stare into the void.

"I heard that this Saturday, Lindsay will be at Green's. I was planning on going anyway and since the two of you had quite the time flirting last time-" Steve rolls his eyes so hard it must hurt "- I thought I'd ask you whether we'd go there." Trying his best to sound casual, he adds: "You know, with you now knowing the ins and outs of charming someone on the dancefloor."

Bucky vigilantly watches Steve from the corner of his eyes while pretending to fidget with the newspaper. Steve's body seems frozen for a moment, the unfocussed staring turning into something else as his eyes narrow. He very slowly puts his cup down. Then, everything happens very quickly.

Steve rushes to Bucky, bracing himself with this left arm in front of his chest and pushing Bucky against the wall. Bucky is too stunned to do anything but to produce a small, surprised *Oh* and to prevent himself from bumping his head onto the hard surface. Their bodies are so close to each other, almost as close as they were five days ago at the exact same spot in their apartment but this time, Steve's quick breaths stem from anger. Bucky has seen this expression on his face before, normally directed at bullies just before Steve gets into one of his infamous fights. He himself has never been the target of this look before.

"No. You don't get to talk about it like that. You don't get to pretend that nothing happened, that you just showed me what women want, because that's not what happened. If you wanted it to be that, you damn well should have done that and nothing else."

His voice is low, quiet and rough, clearly communicating his fury and his unwillingness to let this turn into a screaming match. They had had some of those, the most recent one when they had moved in together and Steve had insisted on paying half of the rent even though he had just lost his mother and could barely work any job with his stomach flu.

Bucky knows how proud Steve can be and how angry he can get but somehow, he completely missed how they got to this point now.

“Steve?” he manages to say, his bewilderment just as apparent as Steve’s rage.

“I’m not doing this with you. You mean too much to me, and I can’t believe you’re willing to hurt me like this.” Disappointment starts to seep its way into his words as Steve’s arm that pushed against Bucky’s chest drops to his side.

Still, Bucky has no idea what’s going on but a sense of dread builds in his gut.

“God fucking damn it. You- You look like you have no fucking clue- you-- let me make this real clear for you. I want this. I have wanted this for so long, I sometimes think it’s gonna eat me alive. And then you have the gall to do this, to show me what it could be like without ever meaning to actually- Fuck.” A deep breath shudders through Steve and Bucky has the intense urge to reach out and pull Steve into a hug, promising to make this right. But he doesn’t.

“And you don’t get to tell me that you didn’t want something, that you didn’t want me right there because our walls are real fucking thin and I won’t pretend I didn’t hear your soft moans as you touched yourself right after. Not to mention how hard you were the entire time. So don’t give me that bullshit.”

Bucky feels the blood leaving his face and his heart sinking as the dread he has felt the entire time closes its long fingers around his throat. He is right, Steve is absolutely right and Bucky had always known he was a coward but to hear Steve say it so clearly makes it so much realer. So much more unbearable.

After a small pause, Steve’s expression softens into resignation, which makes Bucky want to crawl into the nook behind the kitchen door where they keep the broom.

“I don’t know what you see in me-“ Bucky opens his mouth to interject, maybe he can still fix this, but Steve shoots him a warning glare that makes all of words he might have said vanish into thin air. “-and I guess I never will. Sometimes, you look at me so gentle, so earnest that I start to wonder what you see and what that means to you. But I don’t know because I’ve never asked and I will never ask. And you’re not gonna tell me, because you’re not willing to see this through, for real.”

The silence that follows is damning and Bucky knows it. But he still can’t bring himself to say anything, to promise something he might not be able to keep, not to Steve.

“And unless you are, we’re never speaking of this again. Let’s just – go back to the way things were because I will not loose you over this.”

The determination on Steve’s face is as unwavering as always and Bucky just looks at him, nodding slowly as treacherous tears fall on his cheeks.

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Steve almost reconsiders when Bucky gets his letter. Knowing the day Bucky leaves for the army makes him wonder whether he has made the right choice. They might never see each other again and he hates that they might have had something nice, something real together before Bucky got yanked away to risk his life.

At least this is a war worth fighting, against an enemy that has to be defeated and if Steve had any opportunity to fight himself, he would. But the myriad of issues with his body are just as unpopular with the army as they are with his dates.

As he looks at Bucky, packing his things with silent determination, the dark hair still messy and his curved lips drawn to thin, pale lines, Steve almost reaches out to pull him into a kiss. But he doesn't. He is too afraid what it means that Bucky didn't want to see things through before and he wants to keep on good terms with his best friend, now that he's about to leave. And so, when Bucky glances in his direction, something uncertain and vulnerable flickering across his face, Steve smiles a safe, affirming smile and turns away to let him fold his clothes on his own.

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God, it is weird to look at him. This hunk of a man, muscles visible even under the thick cover of a leather jacket, tall and solid as a tree, not a trace of ill-health – but it is Steve, his hair so soft-looking, his mannerism as they always were and his eyes occasionally sparkling with mischief just like when they had snuck into the movie theater through the abandoned backdoor.

Bucky had spent the better part of a day watching Steve, from when he rescued him from the metal table in Azzano until the evening when official business with the brass swept him away. He could not believe it, started to think he was still there in this horrible medical facility, someone messing with his mind and letting him believe that this buff guy was, in fact, Steven Grant Rogers. But whenever he heard him speak or roll his eyes quickly with the familiar huff or did something else so *Steve*, Bucky was convinced that it was him and that he had really rescued all of them.

And still, even though weeks have now passed, Bucky cannot keep himself from staring as they sit watch while the rest of the Howling Commandos try to get some sleep before storming another Hydra base tomorrow. He has to actively force himself to look back at the dark forest, listening for any sign of incoming trouble and yet, the only thing he hears is the steady breath of a man he saw dying of pneumonia and asthma more times than he can bear to remember. It would be great news that Steve is finally healthy if it didn't come with the slight drawback of him fighting in this goddamn war and plunging head-first into any operation deemed to dangerous for mortal men – despite his very much intact mortality.

“You ever think of home?” Steve asks so quietly it’s almost inaudible, startling Bucky out of his train of thought.

“Hm? Oh. Yeah, of course. I miss that time, I miss it every minute,” Bucky replies, trying his best to be honest without letting the extent of sorrow seep into his voice. Steve must hear it anyways because he turns to Bucky and puts his warm hand on his shoulder.

“We’ll make it back.”

Bucky doesn’t say anything and just looks into Steve’s eyes, barely visible in the dark. He seems so sure of it and yet, Bucky can’t shake the uneasy feeling that they will never make it back home. An ache surges in him, the ache to hug his best friend, not this Captain America with his patented reassuring voice but Steve, the guy from Brooklyn who always knows what’s right and what’s wrong and who can be so fucking annoying about it. Because it isn’t just that Steve is now built like a brick shithouse, he’s also starting to sound like someone with power, like someone who doesn’t know what it’s like to live in a shoebox apartment and scrape together just enough for a notepad and a pencil to draw.

“I’m still me, Buck,” Steve whispers as if he had read Bucky’s thoughts. “You know that, right?”

And Bucky has to blink once, twice to shoo away the tears that have started to form against his will.

“I know,” he says and scoots a little closer so that their arms touch and their thighs press together.

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It’s not that Steve minds Bucky looking at him. But it sometimes scares him when he catches Bucky staring at him as if he was a different person, as if he didn’t really know him and was trying to figure out whether he liked him. It unnerved him to the extent he started to notice the patterns – Bucky frowned whenever he went full-on Captain mode, trying to speak as if he was aiming to inspire the nation. Of course it was unnatural, but seeing Bucky react this way made Steve ask himself whether he wanted to be like this, sound like this and quickly came to the conclusion that no, he’d rather talk he did all his life. He still used the Cap voice, sometimes, but less and less around the Commandos. It made him feel easier somehow, more like himself to fall back into his slight Brooklyn accent and swear to his heart’s delight.

A few days after this realization, he felt the familiar urge to draw and very suddenly missed the rustle of paper under a pencil he hadn’t enjoyed since before the serum. So, when the opportunity had presented itself, he nicked a plain empty notebook from a Hydra office together with some pencils and started to scribble every night, when they were all eating and telling stories.

Tonight, he gets his sketchbook out early, starting to draw just as the sun is setting to capture some of the reflections on the river they are camping next to. When he looks up, he catches Bucky's eye for a second as he smiles, cautiously and softly. Steve's heart starts to pound like it used to whenever he took the stairs and he quickly turns back to his sketch. It's his choice not to know what Bucky feels when he smiles at him like that.

Around him, the others are chatting as always, and Steve barely listens with half an ear when his name is mentioned.

"Huh?" he asks as he unglues his eyes from the rough paper in front of him.

"I said, the ladies must have fallen over themselves to have you draw them," Dum Dum repeats as Steve barks out a laugh, glancing at Bucky who is failing at suppressing an amused smirk. Steve shakes his head at the thought and takes a moment to answer.

"Not at all. I didn't look like this before the serum and, believe me, the ladies only had eyes for Bucky wherever I went, so none of them even knew about my meager talent," Steve eventually explains, not quite knowing how he feels about sharing this with these men, when Bucky lets out an indignant noise.

"Meager talent? Christ, Steve, you could have been an artist if you hadn't been too busy surviving every infection and virus known to man," he protests. "Don't you dare undersell my best friend's work like that."

The others laugh at Bucky's spirited defense of Steve's artistic abilities while Steve lowers his head for just a second to enjoy the warmth the words kindled deep inside his chest. He wonders whether Bucky is also thinking of the many evenings he had spent sketching Bucky shaving before a date or smoking on the fire escape or lazily slouching in the kitchen on one of his few days off. God, he really missed home, too.

This time when he continues his sketch, he pays attention to the conversation.

"So, Barnes, we hear you were quite the – ah comment dire ça – ladies' man?" Jacques teases in an effort to hear more.

"Yes, sir. Guess I'm just good company," Bucky replies with false modesty.

"So, no steady girl to go back to after the war, then?" Gabe picks up the thread.

"No, sir, it's the bachelor life for me."

"Well, you know what they say about bachelors, even the ones who get the girls," Monty mutters and Steve immediately tenses while making an effort to keep on drawing.

"What's that supposed to mean now, Monty?" Bucky says clearly, now with an overt edge to his voice.

“Sometimes they charm not just the women,” Monty retorts and suddenly, nobody moves. Time seems to stop as everybody just waits for what happens now. Unexpectedly, it is Jim who speaks next.

“Even if, good for the Sarge if he gets who he wants. Plus, he’s not fishing in our dating pool with that.”

Saying that is brave, really brave and Steve knows it, silently thanking god for Jim Morita and his no-nonsense attitude towards just about everything. Another moment passes and the men just shrug, seemingly agreeing with Jim’s reasoning and Monty nods along with a short delay. Steve doesn’t look anywhere except his sketchbook for a while, but when the conversation has drifted to the base of last week, the one where they had found Nazi books on Aryan mythology, he risks a quick glance at Bucky. He seems to have recovered well from the tense moment, laughing along and sharing his own quips and jokes with the men. When their eyes meet, a subtle sadness sets into Bucky’s expression, quickly wiped away as he adds to the conversation once again, now sporting a toothy grin.

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A whole lifetime of pain and sorrow later, the soldier looks at this man who had said his name. He, of course, remembers neither his name nor said lifetime but there is something stirring in him when he looks at the defiantly squared shoulders and determined jaw. And that’s new.

The soldier has felt things before, terror at the thought of the next wipe, fear of the merciless cold of cryo, humiliation when he was carded around like furniture. But this feeling is different, it stems from a different time – and time is tricky when the last thing you can remember is receiving your instructions after the latest wipe.

So, when the man commands him to stand down, telling him he is his friend, that he doesn’t have to do this, another emotion surges: anger. How dare he tell him what he does and doesn’t have to do when he has no idea how they can make him comply. The soldier flings himself into the fight, more furious than he has ever felt before with the familiar weight of guns and knives strapped to his gear and does his best not to listen to the man.

But he keeps talking and at some point, drops his shield and stops resisting the soldier’s brutal movements, even when he starts to bash his face in. He is durable, his body enhanced by something the soldier recognizes faintly without being able to make sense of it, but beyond the strength of his body, he still looks defiant and determined, even with blood smeared across his abdomen and purple bruises forming on his cheekbones.

The soldier hesitates, long enough for the flash of a memory to distract him – a man, much smaller than this one, his face switching from rage to resignation to determination, his eyes locked with his own. As the soldier pants, completely overwhelmed from the breadth of emotion the image holds, the man falls into the river. And that should be enough, he is

unconscious and he will drown, most likely. The soldier can fulfill his mission without any additional efforts.

But his body lurches forwards, following the man into the river, diving deeper to grab a hold of his uniform and drag him to the surface. The cold water hurts in the places where his flesh is connected with the metal, but he doesn't consider giving up. Physical discomfort is no reason to abort a mission – except this is not his mission. This is the opposite of his mission.

Looking at the man as he hauls him onto dry land, he automatically checks for vitals. The man breathes. He will live. The soldier leaves him there to be found.

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They are sparring when the call finally comes. Steve loosens his stance after dodging Bucky's left hook and grabs his phone.

"Yeah?"

"If it's not my second least favorite hundred-year-old man! How's your brainwashed murder boyfriend?" Tony quips and Steve rolls his eyes so hard Bucky audibly snickers.

"Oh, he's there? How incredibly rude of me. Please send my best wishes to my least favorite old man and my apologies for the nickname. What I meant to call him was, of course, your very well-adjusted roommate with homicidal tendencies."

"Tony, you called me. I suspect there's a reason?"

"There is and it actually includes both of you centenarians, if you can believe it."

He almost can't, with how long it took to get Bucky cleared for missions after Fury's team of psychologists and neurologists had suggested he was ready for the field. It hadn't been easy, none of it, and the months Bucky had spent in and out of dissociative states between remembering missions and his life before he was robbed of his autonomy had proven to be some of the most difficult of Steve's life in the new century. But he hadn't complained, he isn't the one who had been tortured and stored for 70 years and caring for Bucky had helped to soothe the sharp sting of guilt Steve felt every time the Winter Soldier came up. And then Bucky got better, his bad days becoming fewer and fewer and he had immediately insisted that he wanted to use his abilities for good. Tony was understandably pissed, with the Winter Soldier killing his parents and all, but in Steve's opinion, he should really be a bit more willing to make the distinction between the lethal tortured shell of a man and Bucky. He will come around eventually, Steve hopes, and today just isn't that day.

"We're all ears," Steve says, smiling at Bucky.

Steve decides to hit the gym showers before the briefing and lets the hot water trickle down his chest just a moment longer than he strictly needs to. The prospect of a mission with Bucky is more overwhelming than he was prepared for, excitement and glee for his friend mixing with anxiety. Because this really needs to go well, otherwise they might not get another opportunity to show the team just how committed Bucky now is to protecting people. Steve sighs as he turns off the shower, instantly missing its comforting warmth and for a second, he wishes he could just spend the evening with his sketchbook and his best friend.

On their way to Tony's tower, Steve watches Bucky out of the corner of his eye. He's chewing on the inside of his cheek and doing his best not to fidget with the duffle bag on his lap, his anticipation barely concealed by the casual expression on his face.

"So, are you looking forward to it?" Steve breaks the silence in the car.

"Let's see – I've been wanting to do something worthwhile ever since I remembered I was a person. So yeah, I'd say so," Bucky answers, his tone casual but Steve can feel the weight behind his words. He risks a glance and tries an encouraging smile that Bucky returns before focusing on the road again.

"Now that we have everyone here, we can start braiding each others' hair and make friendship bracelets," Tony starts and Natasha thankfully stops him from wasting more time by cutting in. "There's a guy we need to chip. We found him for that one mission we can't tell you about and he's slipped through our fingers more times than I'm comfortable with. But he has a weakness for this one club we've managed to locate, and we know for a fact that he will be there tonight. The only drawback is that the event is all about this German band, no need to know anything about them, but it is crucial that whoever goes in speaks German like a native." She looks at Bucky who slowly nods. "The good thing is that the guy is in no way connected to Hydra, so he won't recognize someone who looks an awful lot like the Winter Soldier. He also loves attention and swings all ways."

"Oh, so when you need someone to flirt their way around some Germans, you think of me?" Bucky asks, amused and apprehensive at the same time.

"Good guess, though. You could charm the socks off of anyone if you set your mind to it," Steve grins knowingly, the familiar ache he has chosen to ignore ever since Bucky made his way back to New York rising in his chest.

"Not just the socks, if my father's annoyance at your success with women is justified in the slightest," Tony adds before inevitably ending on a harsh note. "Oh yeah, the father you murdered, that one."

"Tony, can you drop it for just a minute?" Steve sighs as he feels Bucky tensing next to him.

“Steve, what would you say if I introduced you to my old buddy, close friend and cherished roommate Tuberculosis – your mother did die of TB, right? How would you feel about that?”

“Firstly, TB doesn’t have Bucky’s unparalleled sense of humor – something you’re also gravely lacking, by the way – and secondly, possibly more importantly, TB wasn’t tortured for the better part of a century into killing anyone,” Steve retorts, now blatantly annoyed and unwilling to hide it. “I get that you don’t want to spend movie nights with Bucky and that’s fine, but I think it’s time you drop the accusatory comedy routine on the job, for fuck’s sake.”

This gets even Natasha’s attention, and no one says anything for a few long, nerve-wracking seconds until Tony sighs deeply, a resigned frown settling on his face.

“As Nat was saying, we wanted you for this job because you speak German without an accent and barely anyone knows your face. Since the issue with the trigger words is still a thing, Steve will also be there, surveilling the situation from the VIP lounge so he has enough time to get to you in case someone says as much as the first two words,” Tony explains in a neutral tone of voice, addressing Bucky directly for the first time.

“Sounds like a plan. I’m in,” Bucky says, a little more softly than he usually would, and blinks reassuringly. Tony meets his eyes with an intent stare and gets up.

“So long, Sarge.”

Now with just the three of them in the room, Bucky visibly relaxes, his hands unclenching and his broad shoulders moving as if to gently shake off the tension.

“That went surprisingly well. Good job, Cap.”

“Thanks, Nat.”

They smirk at each other, and Steve thinks of how much he misses her ever since she and the others left for the current mission that has dragged on for months.

“Where’s Sam, by the way?” Bucky asks curiously. Him and Sam get along so well, everyone kind of forgets that their first real encounter ended with Sam losing a wing and being kicked off a helicarrier. But then again, Sam is the most reasonable one and, more importantly, enjoys teasing his friends just as much as Bucky does.

“He’s maneuvering a mini-Redwing into the club, so Steve has visuals on you in addition to sound. Oh and, Steve, when Tony said VIP lounge, he of course meant an abandoned storage closet,” Natasha smiles at Steve who gently lays down his forehead on the glass conference table. Bucky muffles a chuckle, coughing to cover it more thoroughly and proceeds to clear his voice as if he had choked on a sip of water he didn’t drink.

“And you will have both Sam’s and my support from the outside. The plan is for the two of you to sneak in, Bucky disguised as a janitor hauling a small dumpster containing Steve

to the storage closet, cue the costume change and Bucky moves through the vents to the bathrooms, emerging as any other party guest would," Natasha explains so matter of fact it had to be an act, Steve suspects with another groan. Great, not only will he be forced into a physical closet (not that he ever managed to escape the metaphorical one), but he will be disguised as literal trash.

Bucky, on the other hand, sounds first and foremost entertained with the details of the plan. "What about my arm?"

"We have found the perfect way to disguise it; we just have to complete the outfit which is actually our next step. The schedule is as follows: Makeover preparations, pre-mission snacks and then we're off."

Natasha winks at Steve as she opens the door for both men to step out of the room and follow her down the hall.

"So, Bucky, did your career as an eligible bachelor teach you how to dress properly or did people just find your face that handsome?"

"Actually, I always asked Steve what to wear. He's always had an eye for these things, even when he was still colorblind. It's the artist in him, I guess," Bucky states as they round the corner to find large rows of various clothes in different sizes.

On a clothing rack next to an array of shoes, a dark, metallic mesh top with integrated fine gloves gives them an idea of Natasha's brilliant plan for Bucky's arm. Steve automatically scans the pants, finding grey baggy jeans with black splashes of paint that would fit Bucky well, especially with a belt and with a loose black tank top that would show of his ridiculously ripped torso Steve never thinks about. Maybe add a simple chain necklace and some silver rings and Bucky would look – well, appropriately dressed. And handsome as all hell, but Steve also avoids that thought as best he can.

Bucky is already inspecting the fine mesh with its intricate patterns and nods approvingly.

"What do I combine this with to look appealing and available then, Rogers?"

"I don't know, you're not in the habit of being available to me, Barnes," Steve mirrors Bucky's challenging tone while betraying his words by collecting the items he has already put together for the outfit. When he turns, he sees Natasha's raised eyebrows and hastily adds: "With you hiding out god knows where for weeks after the Potomac, I mean."

He shoves the pants, tank top and accessories into Bucky's hands, turning to leave the room for him to try the outfit on. Natasha follows him and sports a wide grin as they close the door but refrains from saying anything as they wait outside. Bucky looks predictably breathtaking in the clothes and Natasha claps with glee while Steve just stares at the ceiling.

"I think this demands some smudged eyeliner. But you'll have to do that in the closet, otherwise you might draw too much attention as the janitor. I'm sure Steve can help you,

with him being an artist and all," Natasha smirks again and Steve has the inkling suspicion that they will be having a highly awkward conversation in the very near future.

"Good idea. I always wanted to try that just for fun, you know," Bucky says cheerfully.

"Before we start this conversation, I want you to know that I'm still uncomfortable in elevators ever since STRIKE tried to capture me in one, so I'd really appreciate it if you didn't make it worse," Steve tries to pre-empt Natasha's next move as they leave the lab where Bucky gets a demonstration for the tracker injection pen.

"I've literally had to torture people as a training exercise. Making you squirm in a confined space doesn't even register on the scale of my bad deeds." Natasha shakes her head as the metal doors close and pauses for a second, just long enough for Steve to hope he might avoid whatever she intends to inflict on him. Finally, she asks: "How did I not know the two of you were a thing?"

"Probably because we're not."

"But you were."

"No, we weren't. Believe me," Steve huffs.

"But you had a thing going on."

"Also no."

"So, nothing ever happened between you?" Natasha asks, turning fully to Steve who knows better than to respond, instead shifting his gaze to the ceiling and wishing for the elevator to hurry the fuck up.

"I see. And what are you doing about it now?"

"Who says there's anything to do something about?"

"The fact that you were clearly checking him out when he got out of the mesh top," Natasha challenges.

"Was not! I was merely looking at the fabric because I was a little anxious it might rip."

"Interesting."

"Is it?"

"Yes, because neither one of us was in the room when Bucky changed."

Steve closes his eyes and curses himself for walking straight into Natasha's bluff.

"It's very interesting, the things people choose to lie about. You should pay attention to it, really tells you a lot," Natasha winks at him as the elevator doors finally open.

After the two-hour drive on which Natasha insists to listen to the song “Wouldn’t it be nice” on repeat, even after both Bucky and Steve pointed out that neither one could relate in the slightest to the wish to be older, Steve is almost glad to be stuffed into a dumpster. It all goes smoothly and soon, Bucky opens the lid in the stuffy storage closet, barely illuminated by the light pouring through the crack beneath the door.

“You getting out of there or are you planning to stay Mr. Trashman for the entire mission?” Bucky whispers and visibly suppresses laughter at the sight of Steve’s unimpressed face.

“Very funny. You getting into your party clothes or did I share the dumpster with this duffle bag for nothing?” he retorts quietly while handing Bucky his outfit and starting to climb out of the bin without knocking anything over or producing any other loud sounds.

After watching him struggle for a few moments, Bucky extends his hand and supports Steve’s weight when he almost falls over. Now with both his feet on the unpleasantly sticky floor, Steve notices how narrow the closet is. He should have stayed in the dumpster, he thinks to himself as Bucky takes off his overalls and slips into the pants. At least he’s already wearing the top so Steve doesn’t have to endure the sight of his bare chest from the corner of his eye. God, this closet was a bad idea.

“Nat was definitely right to suggest for you to do my eyeliner. Even with a mirror, I can’t see shit in here.”

Bucky hands him the unfamiliar, dark pencil and closes his eyes.

A really, really bad idea, Steve thinks to himself for the umpteenth time as he shuffles closer to place his left hand on Bucky’s face while attempting to gently draw a line as close as possible to Bucky’s lashes. His eyes twitch upon impact and Steve immediately apologizes.

“Sorry, sorry, I didn’t mean to hurt you.”

“It didn’t hurt, I’m just not used to it. Go on.”

Again, Steve grips eyeliner pencil as he comes near Bucky’s eyelids that flutter noticeably, but less severely so that Steve manages a semi-straight line across. He takes a deep breath before moving to the other side and does his best not to feel Bucky’s shallow breath falling on his throat.

“Okay, so now I guess you have to smudge it? Carefully, and to the side, but close to the eyes and not in circles, Natasha said. You better do that, I don’t know how much pressure is fine.”

Bucky does as he’s told and absentmindedly starts to hum, so quiet Steve barely hears it.

“This good?” he asks Steve whose enhanced vision allows him to realize that he should have drawn another line under Bucky’s lower lashes to balance the look.

“I mean, the upper part is fine, but I think we should do the same in the lower half of your eye. Can you--“ Steve starts as he tips Bucky’s head back so that he now stares at the ceiling. “And just look up, yeah, like this. This should work.”

He leans in again, carefully lining the pencil up just below Bucky’s waterline and applying the dark color. Without thinking about it, he hums the same melody as Bucky moments earlier. It is only when he has finished this second challenging round of make-up application that the words of the song come to him. *You know it seems the more we talk about it, It only makes it worse to live without it. But let's talk about it. Wouldn't it be nice?* The lyrics hit him hard as he looks into Bucky’s stormy eyes, his hand lingering on his jaw for a moment longer than strictly necessary before he pulls back. Suddenly, the air seems almost liquid with the thick yearning that pours out of Steve with every breath, and he has to grab hold of the wall to not stagger.

“I think that should do it,” Steve murmurs as Bucky gently drags his fingers across his eyes and he can see the purposefully messy result that perfectly matches the vibe of his outfit.

“Rogers, Barnes, get a move on, we don’t have all night. Our guy might be here any minute and-“

“-and there’s only a thirty second window to get to him before he disappears into his private, heavily guarded booth, I know,” Bucky completes Sam’s sentence as he opens the air vents and efficiently climbs up without any trouble. “See you later, Steve.”

“Enjoy the party, just not too much,” Steve replies and attempts winking to cover for the shakiness in his voice.

They have a lot more time, it turns out, as their mission target fails to show up for another one and a half hours. Thanks to the camera feed broadcasting to Steve’s mini pad, he can watch closely as Bucky loiters around some German goths, seamlessly joining their conversation and doing a round of shots with them. After a few songs, he excuses himself and moves to the dance floor, seemingly lost to the rhythm but Steve can tell just how vigilant he actually is. Nevertheless, he moves his body effortlessly, flowing with the music and throwing his head back for a moment, catching sight of the tiny Redwing above and smiling ever so slightly. Steve tenses, closes his eyes and very deliberately lets the air escape through his nostrils. It’s good to see Bucky like this, focused on a mission while dancing like the natural he is and just himself in every way. As much as he’s changed, much less boisterous than he was before the war, more reserved and with a sharp edge to his humor, he’s still so very *Bucky*, it threatens to take Steve’s breath.

“Barnes, we have visual on our man. His car will arrive in a minute, max, and then he’ll enter the building through the door on your six,” Nat’s voice announces and Bucky turns around as if it was a random dance move, subtly finding his way closer to the door. When the tall bald man with a tight shirt and even tighter suit pants emerges, Bucky glances over the crowd, catching their target’s eye and lingering for second before smirking slightly and

looking elsewhere. The man slows down a bit, clearly checking Bucky out who lets him do just that as he turns his head again and beckons him to join him. For a second, his counterpart hesitates but when Bucky chuckles disarmingly, he moves in closely and the two start to sway to the music, now pressed up against each other. Through his earpiece, Steve can hear the man's low voice as he starts to talk, the tone obviously flirty and promptly rewarded with Bucky's warm laughter that sounds so misleadingly genuine. The jealousy climbing down Steve's spine is sudden and merciless, leaving behind an emptiness that has him blankly staring at the screen in his hands.

"And we have Tony's confirmation – the tracker is active. Nice job, people. Let's get out of here," Natasha states, startling Steve who was just as entranced by Bucky as the man who got a microchip injected.

"Wow, that guy was bland," Bucky sighs as he removes his earpiece and mutters under his breath: "Scheiß Almanns."

Amused and a little bit impressed, Natasha cocks an eyebrow.

"Someone's keeping up with the youth."

"My therapist makes me watch German reality TV so I can avoid getting triggered by random tourists discussing their dinner plans."

"And there I was, thinking you just lied to me when you spent the entire weekend hogging the remote and binging on whatever stupid show that was," Steve huffs.

"Maybe she didn't say I have to watch five seasons in a row but, in the end, it helped, so it was the right thing to do all along," Bucky retorts as Sam enters the room, approvingly clapping a hand on his shoulder.

"Barnes, you really outdid yourself. I almost believed you wanted to go home with that guy, practice your language skills some more."

"I might be bisexual but boring arms dealers really aren't my type," Bucky says with ease and Steve does his best not to whip his head around to stare at him. It baffles him how effortlessly Bucky jokes about it, not a hint of discomfort in his voice. Trying to focus on anything else, Steve asks:

"Arms dealer?"

"There are some things you pick up after seventy years as a brainwashed assassin." Bucky sounds amused, as if it was so very obvious.

"You must have, you were flirting like a pro," Sam reasons as he pats Bucky's shoulder once more.

“Oh, that wasn’t Hydra training. They were all about, you know, efficient murder and occasionally stomach-churning torture. Not all that interested in leaving good impressions. Tonight was all me, James Buchanan Barnes at your service.” Bucky sports a cocky grin, obviously satisfied with himself. It must have been a different century, the last time Steve saw this expression, and he can’t help but return it.

“Told you, there’s no one he can’t charm the socks off of.”

“Well, that’s not quite true – unless you’re barefoot in those boots,” Bucky responds with a wink and a pointed glance at Steve’s footwear before he steps out of the room, heading to the bathroom he was told to change in.

Steve’s heart starts to beat rapidly after briefly standing still as he gapes at the now closed door. From the corner of his eye, he sees Natasha chuckling silently and Sam looking just as baffled as him.

“Dude-“

“Nope. Don’t even think of talking about it,” Steve asserts in his best attempt at his patented Cap voice as he gingerly walks outside to wait by the car.

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They’re both quiet on the drive back to their heavily fortified Brooklyn apartment – Steve’s apartment, to be entirely accurate, but Bucky has lived there ever since he had shown up at the doorstep, when he was finally confident he wasn’t about to kill anyone. Something had still felt off when he had first raised his hand to knock, and he had turned around, not wanting to invite himself without at least bringing a gift. Someone had raised him better than this, he suspected although he had no idea who that person was. It took him just fourteen minutes to find a shop with art supplies and steal a nicely bound sketchbook with thick paper and three different pencils. Knocking was much easier the second time. The man opening the door had stared at him, hastily let him as if he might disappear from the hallway and taken the present without even looking at it. Even in those first few days, when he barely talked and couldn’t remember enough to trust it, being around Steve had been easy, familiar.

And it still is, in a way, although an ever-growing ache had started to settle into the pit of his stomach every time he looks at Steve for too long or notices just how beautiful his laughter sounds. It had taken Bucky some time to figure out what exactly was happening and that this feeling was far from new, remembering bit by bit for how long he had carried this longing with him. He had planned to talk to Steve about it before his first mission, finally apologize and set things – well, not straight, but right. But he chickened out too many times and now they are almost home, debriefed after this admittedly miniscule mission and the comfortable silence between them has turned into a thick fog of unspoken words.

“How about a celebratory beer – or do you want to turn in early today?” Steve asks on their way up the stairs.

“Beer’s good,” Bucky tries to sound casually pleased with the idea and not wrecked with nerves.

“Used to be a lot better when we could actually get drunk, though. I’m still annoyed the serum took me from lightweight to completely unaffected, I gotta say.”

In the dark, Bucky can barely make out Steve’s wistful expression becoming distinctly more sour for just a second before he unlocks the door to let both of them in. Inside, Bucky automatically heads for the balcony as Steve fetches them two bottles, checking on the assortment of herbs he planted there. After his first week here, he had decided that Steve’s spice rack was sorely lacking and needed some additions, preferably ones that would regrow. Steve had watched him potting the rosemary and basil with a guarded smile, leaning against the frame of the balcony door and squinting in the bright sun of an early noon. Now in the dark, Steve places himself in the exact same spot and gives Bucky his beer who takes it without looking at him.

“You were right, you know?” Bucky admits, bracing himself and takes his first sip.

“That’s because I always am,” Steve asserts confidently and Bucky can hear the smile he’s wearing, a performance of smugness laced with self-deprecation. After a moment passes without a reaction from Bucky who is busy steading his breath, Steve follows it up: “Right about what, Buck?”

“What you said back then. That I wasn’t ready to see this through – you were right about that.” The ensuing silence is deafening despite the city’s noises transported through the cool air. It’s the kind of quiet only produced by people freezing in their place so completely that even the wind has the decency not to ruffle their hair or tug at their clothes.

“I-“ Steve starts before clearing his throat. “I didn’t think you- you ever thought about it. Or remembered now, I guess.”

Bucky sighs deeply, the knot in his stomach twisting painfully.

“I remember. And god, I wanted to tell you how sorry I am for such a long time.”

Defying his sense of dread, Bucky manages to turn around and directly look into Steve’s inscrutable face.

“I’m sorry, Steve. I fucked up. At first, I was so overwhelmed at what I was feeling and then, then I actually considered telling you about it. But all I could think of was how difficult it would be and how you always stand up for what was right and- if anyone would have accused us of anything, you might have chosen a fight that was just that little bit more dangerous and maybe never made it home.” Another deep breath to keep his voice from cracking. “It’s really fucking unfair because that shouldn’t have been my decision, it should have been yours, but I can be so goddamn selfish sometimes, it makes me sick to

think about it. I made that choice because I couldn't bear the thought of loosing you, not when I had almost lost you so many times before."

Realization slowly seeps into Steve's expression, and his stance loses its edge as his shoulders drop ever so slightly and he gently furrows his brow. The pause stretches as Bucky gathers his strength to claw the words out of his throat, to finally let them be heard.

"And then I went off to fight in this merciless war and all I could think of was how much I regretted not at least trying to see things through with you and how glad I was you were back home, not getting shot at by goddamn Nazis. But then, you were there, all of a sudden, brawny and healthy as a horse, rescuing me and yelling orders like you were born to it."

Suddenly, the sentences break out of him as his vision starts to blur.

"I had you back and at the same time, I didn't and I knew I had wasted my chance because now I could never make you believe me just how much I loved you, had loved you for years. There's nothing I could have said that would have convinced you that you were beautiful before the army, with your slender wrists and your reliable hands and your collarbones I wanted to kiss so bad. Just as you are beautiful with your broad shoulders and the foot or what you gained in height and your goddamn thighs. The best things about you never changed anyway, your voice, your smile, the sharp look in your eyes."

Inevitably, a tear runs down the side of Bucky's face.

"And when you draw, you look just the same as you always have and it makes me- it makes me want to- it made me want to tell you, because you deserve to know."

A gasp of air fills Bucky's lungs as he clutches the bottle in his hands, looking at his feet and willing his body to stop shaking. He hears the sound of a bottle being put on the windowsill and lifts his head as Steve takes Bucky's beer, sets it down next to his own and steps close, so close, carefully placing his hands on either side of Bucky's face. His thumb traces the wet path of Bucky's tear, from his jaw over his cheekbone to the edge of his eye. Steve rests his forehead against Bucky's, inhaling deeply as if to soak up every bit of his presence before tilting his head downwards and kissing him. Soft lips meet, gently brushing against each other and something in Bucky cracks open, sending a wave of tenderness through his body. He wraps his arms around Steve, pulling him even closer and kisses him deeply and slowly, opening his mouth and sighing with relief and want as their tongues touch. Suddenly, he feels safer and warmer than he has in decades and all he can do is let himself fall, fall into the kiss and Steve's arms.

Bucky hears a pleased hum and Steve presses them against the balcony's railing that creaks in protest.

"We should probably move inside," Bucky murmurs against Steve's warm lips before kissing him again. Steve nods without breaking the kiss and maneuvers them back inside.

He looks at Bucky after closing the balcony door behind them, his expression soft and incredulous at the same time.

“I don’t know if I was ready, either. You made it easy to just be angry at you and not think about it too hard, at least for a while. I think I’m sorry for that, too,” Steve almost whispers, his eyes wide and earnest. “And when you found your way back, I didn’t want to be greedy because I’m genuinely just so glad to have you back, whatever that looks like.”

For a moment, they just look at each other, and Bucky can’t believe they really made it here, almost a century late and Steve just as unbelievably *Steve* as always. Letting his smile broaden, Bucky puts his hand on Steve’s chest and tugs him closer by his t-shirt. “I think I like you greedy,” he breathes just below his ear and starts kissing his neck, biting him slightly, right above his collarbones and reveling in Steve’s delicious moan. Their next kiss is intense and hot, both breathing harder as their hands start to roam. Bucky feels Steve’s thumb nudging under his sweater, finding his sensitive stomach and slowly caressing the soft skin.

“I really hate to interrupt this, but I need to shower so bad. I still have German club sweat coating every inch of my body,” Bucky murmurs apologetically, silently cursing the uninspired arms dealer and his poor nightlife choices.

“A shower might be nice,” Steve responds while dragging his fingers over the edge of Bucky’s pants and boxers. “We could share, save some water.”

“It’s not the Great Depression anymore, you know?” Bucky grins as he walks backwards to the bathroom with his thumbs hooked into Steve’s beltloops who comes along, smiling while taking his shirt off. Mirroring the gesture, Bucky gets out of his hoodie and unceremoniously strips off his sweatpants. Breathing heavily, Steve looks at him, his eyes slowly wandering up and down his almost naked body and Bucky, just for a second, starts to feel self-conscious.

“Can I touch you?” Steve asks reverently, stepping closer as he undoes his belt and slips out of his trousers. With a quick nod, Bucky takes Steve’s hand and places it on his chest where webbed scar tissue connects with the metal of his left arm. Steve’s fingers move across his left shoulder, his collarbone onto the other side and back again, drawing a searing trace of anticipation on Bucky’s skin. He closes his eyes as Steve steps closer and lightly places his lips where his hand had been, pulling him in and nuzzling into the crook of Bucky’s neck.

“God, I’ve thought about this so much I’m not sure this is real,” Steve sighs and Bucky tugs him closer.

“This better be real or I’ll feel really guilty about daydreaming this hard about my best friend,” he mumbles in response and they both chuckle before kissing again, years of yearning pouring from their lips as they close the last gaps between their bodies. Bucky presses himself against Steve, slotting his leg between Steve’s thighs and humming

approvingly at the resulting groan, heavy with desire. The soft fabric of their boxers threatens to chafe, so Bucky pulls his off, quickly followed by Steve undressing and breathing heavily at the sight of him. They both smile as Steve draws Bucky closer again who moans at the sensation of Steve's warm skin against his own, their naked bodies now touching everywhere. Steve fits his lips to Bucky's, kissing him urgently and steering them towards the shower.

"Mh, Steve, you have to know I shower with very warm water and do not accept any feedback on the matter."

"I'm very fine with letting you control the temperature, Buck."

It sends a blissful shiver down Bucky's spine to hear Steve call him by this nickname only he uses, his voice rough with desire and his hands firmly on his hips. As he turns on the shower still pressed up against Steve, Bucky can feel him almost hard against himself, and the realization makes him groan into the next kiss. Their hands start to move frantically as the hot water rains on them, wetting Bucky's hair and making it harder to breathe.

Dizzy with hunger, Bucky leans against the wall and Steve steps closer, kissing him again and dragging his hand from Bucky's neck over his chest down his stomach until he gently brushes his hard cock. Bucky moans, helplessly lost in the pleasure of Steve's hand stroking him. He drops his hand to touch Steve's inner thigh which makes him sharply suck in air before Bucky gently wraps his fingers around him, mirroring Steve's pace. The hot water running down Steve's skin drips on Bucky's body as he lifts his hand to his mouth, spits on it and touches Steve again, reveling in the added slickness. Steve starts to pant, rocking back and forth into Bucky's fist quicker and quicker, their lips now hovering over each other. The pleasure builds and builds deep in Bucky's gut, and he lets his head fall back against the wall, opening his eyes and seeing Steve, flushed and focused just on him. With a startled moan, Bucky comes in Steve's hand which sets off his orgasm moments later. They lean against each other, breathless and satisfied, and Steve slowly kisses Bucky again before taking the showerhead and gently washing the come off both their stomachs.

"You know I love you, too, right?" Steve asks so softly Bucky could cry but instead, he just smiles, earnest and glad.

"I really hoped so."

"Your room or mine?" Bucky asks with a smirk on his lips as they step out of the bathroom, still damp from the shower and wearing nothing but boxers.

"Since yours was the storage closet until, well, you came here, I'd say mine. Also, my bed is bigger."

“That’s some rotten hospitality right there, Steven Grant Rogers. Are you not appalled at yourself?”

“Not if it gets you to sleep in my bed.”

With a sly wink, Steve opens the door to his room and mockingly bows as Bucky strolls in who tackles him onto the soft bedspread. They both giggle and Steve pulls Bucky into another kiss, warm and deep and content.

“You know, Nat and Sam will be having a field day with this,” Steve mutters against Bucky’s lips.

“Well, we don’t have to tell them right away, we could just pretend nothing happened and slowly start to get more handsy to see when they call us out for it,” Bucky suggests before reconsidering: “Oh no wait, you’re terrible at lying. They’d know immediately.”

Lightly chuckling, Steve nuzzles into the crook of Bucky’s neck before pulling back, a curious expression on his face.

“Why’d you flirt with me on the mission, Buck?”

“I was trying to force myself to have this talk with you. I thought I’d just make it so obvious, even you should know something’s going on and maybe even say something about it. The possibility of you starting this conversation had me so terrified I knew I would do it myself,” Bucky admits.

“You definitely overestimated me. I was planning to just pretend everything was normal and then spend half the night staring at my ceiling about it.”

Bucky scoffs fondly as he pulls the duvet over them and settles on Steve as soon as he lays down.

“Glad I did finally talk about it - can’t have you loosing sleep over this. You get so grumpy.”

Steve’s chest shakes with a quiet chuckle before he presses a kiss to Bucky’s temple.

“Good night, Buck.”

“Good night, Stevie.”